

i spent 48 hrs with 8-figure entrepreneurs

Channel: Tim Luong · Published: Jul 10, 2026 · Watch: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=HYOf3dm64z0> Source: full transcript

Executive Summary

Tim Luong documents a 48-hour New York trip meeting 8-figure entrepreneurs, touring a fast-scaling startup HQ, and reflecting on why taking business risks early — before life trains you out of it — is essential.

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Arriving in New York & the Night Out 0:00

- Tim arrives in New York and bikes through Central Park to meet his friend Grady
 - Grady is opening a restaurant, so the crew goes to the opening for food and to see where the night takes them
 - Tim jokes he's rusty at biking and describes the streets as "chaos"
- Food highlights on the trip:
 - Greek yogurt parfait with blueberries and strawberries — described as the "go-to order"
 - Mango sticky rice from **Thai Villa, New York** — Tim calls it the best he's ever had
 - Orange gold mochi
- Tim explains his monthly routine of leaving his home base to network in a different city:
 - He had just finished a **3–4 week "lock in"** at his house before this trip
 - Philosophy: "You always need to keep a pulse on what's happening with people and competitors in your space"
 - Building a network and staying in touch reveals what's working in other businesses, keeping you sharp in your own
 - It also serves as an **idea reset**: lock in → go network → reset → go home → grind → repeat
- The crew hits **Shane Margo**, described as a private members lounge in Soho
- Night ends with Tim making a deliberate "Irish goodbye" at 2:00 a.m.
 - Reason: filming and meetings scheduled the next day

- His framing: "You got to know when to fold them" — the night in New York never truly ends (parties run to 4–6 a.m.) but smart prioritization matters
- Reflection on Miami vs. New York lifestyle:
 - In Miami, Tim is "overly optimized" — up early, worked out, working at his desk on Saturdays
 - In New York he lets himself relax — doesn't mind waiting 20 minutes for a table or coordinating with friends
 - "I think it's a balance. If I did this every weekend I think that'd be bad too."
 - His brain at brunch is still nagging: "What work do I have to get done? I need to go back."

Visiting the Startup HQ with Ari 0:33

- Tim visits what he calls the **"HQ"** to catch up with his friend Ari — a regular stop whenever he's in New York
- The company is scaling rapidly:
 - Moving up **one floor** into a much bigger co-working-style space; keeping the current floor as a chill co-working area
 - Opened a **second office in Palo Alto** — all engineering has been relocated to SF
 - **~40–45 engineers** in SF, with **3 new engineers starting every week**
 - **~40 people on the go-to-market team** in New York (sales, marketing, ops, finance)
- Hiring incentives to encourage in-office culture:
 - **\$9,000/year** toward rent if you live within **4 blocks** of the New York office
 - **\$20/day** for lunch via Uber Eats
 - **\$25/day** for dinner via Uber Eats
 - **\$50 Uber home** if you stay past 10:00 p.m.
 - **Free Equinox membership** (there is an Equinox in the building)
- Engineering team culture in SF:
 - Engineers are grouped by division and live together — roughly **10 per house**
 - Divisions include an "ads house" and a "backend engineering house"
 - Described as "straight up locked in" — very Silicon Valley behind-the-scenes
- Executives also live together — Ari mentions **~10 execs** in one building near the NY office
- The office has a **sales gong** — only rings when a deal is significant enough:
 - The bar is **over \$1 million/month** in deal value
 - They close roughly **200 businesses per week** across the 40-person sales team
 - Gong rings **a few times a week**
- Average employee age: approximately **23–24 years old**; Ari himself is 24
- Tim's takeaway on the office culture: "If you want to build a multi-billion dollar plus company, this is how you have to be — everyone under one roof."

Hiring Philosophy & Building a Cracked Team 0:46

- Central thesis from the conversation: **finding the right people is the hardest thing in building a company**
 - "However many interviews you think you need to have to hire great people, it's usually not enough."
- The "cracked people" framework:
 - You only need **10–20 truly exceptional ("cracked") people** to build a billion-dollar company
 - The question isn't headcount — it's: how do you find people who will come in on Saturdays?
 - Ari's company has **~80 full-time employees**; competitors in the same space have **500 employees** and do less revenue
 - "It's not scalable in any capacity. You just need really smart people and they'll figure it out."
- The performance gap between tiers is massive:
 - Tim's framing: the gap between an **A+ player and a B+ player is roughly 10x**
- Every new hire either raises or lowers the company average:
 - "If every person you add doesn't raise the average, they're lowering it."
 - "People either give you energy or they take energy away."
- As a result, Ari's company is **investing heavily in recruiting**:
 - Steven is dedicated to general recruiting
 - Cam is focused specifically on **engineering recruiting**
 - The bar for new hires constantly rises as the team grows

Knicks Game Energy 0:52

- Tim and the crew attend what appears to be a **Knicks playoff game** ("Nix and 5")
- The street energy outside is electric — fans climbing things, crowds cheering
- Tim says he's "genuinely worried for the city" if the Knicks win — "all hell breaks loose"
- The Knicks are up by one; the crew celebrates loudly
- Also watching the **Brazil World Cup game** earlier in the day — the schedule is tight with both events back-to-back

Reflections: Risk, Freedom & Gratitude 0:54

- Sitting in New York grounds Tim and gives him perspective on his own journey
- The Chipotle moment:
 - Tim and his friend Johnny were eating at Chipotle during lunch rush hour
 - Hundreds of young people in button-up suits — likely Wall Street / finance workers — were coming in
 - It was **95°F outside**, yet they had to wear suits and be in an office
 - Tim's reaction: "I can just pick up my stuff and go to New York for the weekend" — a moment of deep gratitude

- Key mindset reframe: stop only comparing upward ("I'm not where I want to be yet") and also **look back at how far you've come**
- The case for taking risk early:
 - Tim was originally on track to work on Wall Street — a **six-figure job straight out of college**
 - The thought that changed everything: "I could always go back and get this job, but I could never start this online business and take risk at 22."
 - His failure math: "If I fail, I'll still be 23, 24. I can do it, fail again. I'll still be 25. You have your whole life ahead of you."
 - But if you wait: **"Life trains you to stop taking risk."**
 - Observation: **as you get older, your ambitions start to dwindle**

"You have to do it now because you can always go back and get that thing — but you can never start this online business and take risk at 22 years old."

- Closing advice:
 - Start an online business
 - Prioritize **freedom** — "What's the point of making money if you can't just go do what you want, when you want?"
 - Aim for a business you can run **from wherever you are**
- Tim plugs the channel: vlogs every month plus business content